known how Babur had routed Ibrahim Lodi's army of 100,000 men – even more than Hemu's – with only 10,000 of his own. But then, Akbar would also have known that Babur had a secret weapon. Gunpowder.[40] Thrown into utter confusion by unexpected explosions, Lodi's army had been routed by noon.

Thirty years later, Akbar had no secret weapon. Gunpowder was so commonplace now that Akbar had ordered his chief of artillery to stuff an effigy of Hemu with it and have it blown up, as a way of cheering his troops and, as likely, himself. All he could do, as he put on his armour and rode those last dusty kilometres towards Panipat, was hope for a miracle.

A miracle is what he got.

Hemu had broken two wings of the Mughal army. Now, he watched as Ali Quli Shaibani's centre unleashed its barrage of arrows across the ditch, and Hemu's embattled elephants retreated just enough to allow the Mughals to charge. Unfazed, Hemu launched a counter-attack with a platoon of musth elephants that roared and 'dislodged many . . . soldiers of the sublime army'.[41] The Mughal position wasn't getting any better. Ploughed through by demented elephants, Ali Quli's cavalry fired desperate arrows into the air.

One of them found its mark.

Hemu the grocer had never learnt to ride a horse. This explains, partly, why he was riding an elephant; though an elephant was also a way for a commander to remain visible, at a height, to his troops. That may be why Hemu wasn't wearing a helmet – so that his men might recognize him easily, and gain heart from his bare courage. It was a brave but reckless decision. The air was thick with arrows and one struck Hemu in the eye, piercing his skull so that, in Badauni's graphic description, 'his brain passed clean out from the cup of his head'.

Ferishta writes that Hemu did not give up despite the mortal blow; that he 'drew the arrow and with it the eye out of the socket, which he wrapt in his handkerchief . . . [and] continued to fight with unabated courage'. Perhaps that is true; Hemu's ambition for power was no less than Akbar's would become. He had even vowed, some say, to convert to Islam if he defeated the Mughals.[42] But willpower alone cannot staunch the effects of an arrow through the eye.